

Chapter 2

The Old Crate

CLICK. On went Cody's pocket flashlight. He couldn't risk slipping on a puddle in the presence of a savage beast.

There wasn't a second to lose. He tiptoed past a labyrinth of woodland trees, keeping an eye out for any monster in hiding. It could have been anything: a mutant wolf, a giant mosquito, or even a ten-foot sleeping paralysis demon. Thankfully, at this point in his life, most of the monsters he had seen were mundane enough to be mistaken for vicious animals. Of course, being alone with a vicious animal in a forest at night was already terrifying enough. With every step he inched forward in the drizzling rain, his heartbeat increased.

Cody spun his back, fearing he had lost track of the trailway he derailed from. He held his breath while examining the trees. There was still no sight of a monster. Unfortunately now, every bush branch and tree twig felt like a beast claw brushing against his legs. The light from his flashlight began to jitter against the tightly packed woods. Its constant movement, casted spotlight on something strange for a split second. The glimpse was too sudden to tell. He flung his light. It confirmed his suspicion. Two enormous scrape marks decorate a narrow trunk. The tree itself was an old aspen, nearly uprooted from what seemed to be a brutal force. It could've been the wind, or it could've been a monster big enough to knock down a tree.

Actually, come to think of it... fighting a monster at night is a really stupid idea. I'm just gonna go home.

Cody thought to himself while slowing his pace down.

He turned and then suddenly stepped on a giant snake's tail.

"AHHHHH!"

Cody leapt and sprinted as fast as he could. His flashlight spazzed in every direction. And then BAM!

He ran headfirst into a thick tree branch and landed flat on his back. He tried to get back up and run again, but his panicked mind just made him run straight into the same tree. This time, he stayed down for a good minute. When his vision cleared again, he noticed his flashlight shining at the snake he had stepped on. It was as thick as a birch tree, and it appeared to be as long as a garden hose. Most interesting of all? It didn't move.

Is he dead?

Cody cautiously crept up to the still reptile, waiting to see if it made a move as subtle as a vibration. However, no, it stayed immobile. By the time he had crept to a dangerously close range, he realized that the giant snake had been sliced into many pieces like a sushi roll.

"What?" Cody then slapped his hand over his mouth, preventing it from making another sound.

Whoever took out this creature, monster or animal, it could probably take out the world's strongest human. I'm truly out of my depth here.

Cody turned once more and calmly walked back to the trailway. It was out of sight but thankfully not too far away. All of a sudden, his foot went down. He didn't trip, but he did feel a heavy thud, like his foot landed on a wooden platform. Shining his light down, Cody saw before him a rotted, wooden trapdoor half-covered in loose dirt.

It was a wooden crate buried into the ground. His mind raced to over a dozen possibilities of what could've been inside. It reminded him of Pandora's box, the story of a woman who opened a mysterious capsule out of burning curiosity which led to all the evils of the world being unleashed. For Cody, he expected the worst thing underneath would've been a dead body from a 20th century mafia gang. Upon thinking about the mafia, he acknowledged a more positive outcome: buried money from an old mafia heist! Cody flung open the trapdoor, ready for anything.

What a disappointment! It was practically empty. At first, Cody thought he was lucky for the crate to be unlocked. Unfortunately, the only things inside were a couple empty bottles and some recycled chess pieces. The only non-trash item inside was a metal plate with the company's insignia, and it was nailed to the bottom. He slammed it back shut and kicked around some leaves and dirt to fully cover it. This crate likely belonged to someone, and he feared whoever would stumble upon it next would not be so charitable to leave it be -- even if everything inside was worthless.

He quickly made his way back to the main road. Unfortunately for him, as he stepped on the wet pavement, he heard the roar of an oncoming vehicle. It was a pickup truck, speeding straight toward him. He had initially anticipated it to brake, but it showed no sign of slowing. By the time it finally screeched to a halt at the crosswalk, the puddles on the dirt road only caused it to hydroplane. It swerved to the side of the road as Cody leapt out of the way. His face first landed on a big rock. This hurt way more than the cumbersome tree by the old crate.

"Oh, give me a break! Come on!" He cried out.

The truck had skidded to a complete stop. The driver couldn't be seen due to a sun glare on the windshield. The only thing he could see inside was a rubber duck hanging from the truck's car mirror. It rocked back and forth like it was just in a storm. The window of the truck rolled down, revealing Penny, the actual real life one. This time, her hair was brown unlike in Cody's dream.

She stepped around, barely able to keep her balance. The sudden stop must've put her in quite the daze.

"I'm so sorry, sir! I couldn't stop the car in time. Are you hurt?" said Penny. "Wait. Cody?"

Penny took her sunglasses off to get a better look at him.

"Penny?"

"Oh my goodness, Cody, I'm so sorry."

"It's okay, worse things have happened to me", said Cody, nervously scratching his back. He slowly picked himself while making his best effort to look Penny in the eyes without getting nervous. "Are you okay?"

"Only my pride's hurt." She shrugged. "I should be the one asking if you're okay."

"Don't worry. Your car didn't even touch me."

"Okay, that's good", said Penny, opening the truck's side door. She pulled out a bottle of orange soda. "Here, take this as a token of apology."

"You're gonna give me diabetes with all these tokens."

"Give it to the poor then."

"Thanks." Said Cody as he took the bottle.

In a world where everybody was a closed book, Penny was a walking theatre production. She expressed herself in every motion, and it made talking with her so easy. Even the way she handed a bottle was meaningful. Most people pointed the cap at the person they're handing it to. Penny oriented the bottle to fit perfectly into the hand of the other.

And now here she was, being concerned for Cody when she didn't even hit him. "Do you really mean it that you're not hurt?" She asked.

Cody nodded.

"In that case," Penny continued, "I need to head out. I've got a million deliveries today!"

"Wooow, a million? Yesterday was only a hundred thousand-"

Penny drove off before he could finish his sentence. Cody stood there in silence, feeling like he could melt into a puddle out of embarrassment. Quite literally, he did feel like he was melting. Drops of water ran down his head, except it wasn't raining.

“Am I sweating that much?”

Cody touched the side of his head and instantly realized he was bleeding. Penny definitely didn't hit him, so this must have been from the rock he jumped onto.

I've gotta stop leaping out of the way whenever I see danger.

Inspecting the dark red marks on his hand, he began to feel light headed. He must've hit that boulder pretty hard. Thankfully, he felt no pain.